



THE ANVIL



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Free



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What is the Melbourne Anarchist Communist Group (MACG)?

The MACG is an organisation of class struggle revolutionary anarchists who share political positions, articulated in theory, strategy and tactics. We aim to encourage struggle by the working class for its own interests and, within that struggle, we aim to advance Anarchist ideas as its necessary philosophical basis.

What is Anarchism?

Anarchism is a social philosophy based upon the principles of liberty, equality and solidarity. It is the political dimension of a free society.

What is Communism?

Communism is the principle of "from each according to their ability, to each according to their need". It is the economic dimension of a free society.

The Anvil is published on the stolen lands of the Wurundjeri and Bunurong peoples of the Kulin Nation. We pay our respects to the elders past and present. Sovereignty over this land was never ceded. It always was and always will be Aboriginal land.

The Labor party: friends of the bosses

In late August, the Albanese Labor government passed legislation aimed at destroying Australia's most militant union, the Construction, Forestry & Maritime Employees Union (CFMEU), imposing a draconian regime of administration that intends to drive down the hard-won wages and conditions of construction workers.

It may seem ironic that a party founded in the wake of industrial action – the Great Shearers' Strike of 1891 – now eagerly sides with the bosses. But this isn't the first time the Labor Party has sold out the working class and it won't be the last. For the Labor party, this is business as usual.

Under Australian capitalism, the Australian Labor Party (ALP) has two functions. On the one hand, the ALP represents the political arm of the trade union bureaucracy. Trade union officials are involved within the ALP at every level of its operation. Of the 20 elected representatives of Labor's 2024 national executive, 12 are current trade union officials. At both the State and National level, half of



the delegates present at Labor Party Conferences are granted to ALP-affiliated trade unions.

The internal politics of the ALP is largely driven by a highly organised factional system. The power of these factions within the party ultimately comes from the strength of their affiliated unions. The Labor Left faction is dominated by the United Workers Union (UWU), the Australian Manufacturing Workers Union (AMWU) and the CFMEU. The primary players in the Labor Right faction are the Australian Workers Union (AWU) and the Shop, Distributive and Allied Employees Association (SDA).

In turn, the factional divide within the Labor Party directs how leading trade union officials act within their unions. For instance, after the media launched its propaganda attack on the CFMEU,



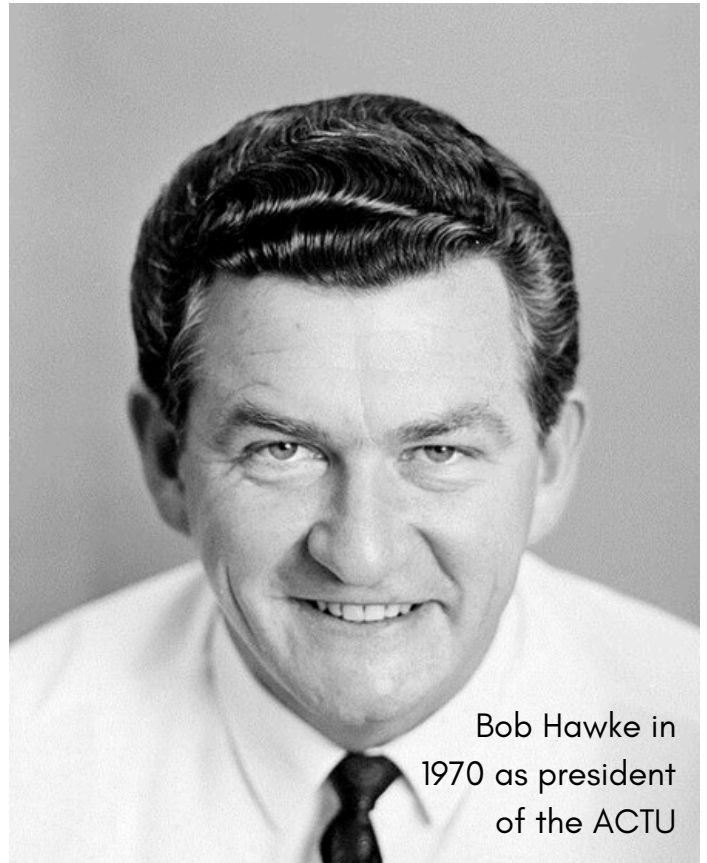
the right wing of the bureaucracy saw an opportunity to crush one of its rivals. Representatives of the SDA pushed the executive of the peak body of the Australian trade union movement, the ACTU, to accept appointing an administrator to the CFMEU. The right wing of the bureaucracy went on the attack, and most of the left wing of the bureaucracy simply capitulated. These are exactly the kinds of problems that we can expect to emerge when the unions are in the thrall of politicians.

The other key function of the ALP is that of competently managing Australian capitalism, in the interests of the capitalists. Just like any other government, the ALP is ultimately beholden to the interests of capitalists and must consistently demonstrate its reliability to them. Labor is useful to Australian capitalists for a number of

reasons. First, it is generally viewed by businesses as being a more reliable source of government funded development. Second, the close relationship between the ALP and the trade union bureaucracy has established Labor as the party best positioned to keep class struggle from getting out of hand. It's no surprise then, that Labor is willing to crush a militant union like the CFMEU to show capitalists just how well it can defend their interests. On the other hand, if Labor's policies ever seriously began to threaten profitability or growth, capitalists would use their legal ownership and control over the economy to force them to back down.

Combining these two functions of the ALP, we see that it is the vehicle by which the union bureaucracy attempts to negotiate a compromise with capital on the overall management of capitalism in Australia. As a result, Labor's policies will always be more conservative than the policies of the unions themselves.

Labor's policies are the product of two balances of forces: the relative power of the trade unions within capitalism and the relative balance in the unions between the bureaucracy and the membership.



Bob Hawke in
1970 as president
of the ACTU

The relationship today between the trade union bureaucracy and the ALP still lies in the long shadow of the Accord of the 1980s. The Accord was an agreement between the union officials and the Labor Governments' of Hawke and Keating, designed to restructure Australian capitalism and reverse the crisis of declining profits. The Accord narrowly confined what unions could legally fight for and, in particular, it set an upper bound on union wage claims. The right to strike was restricted accordingly.

This agreement was a disaster for Australian unions. The Accord compelled the union bureaucracy to act as a police force over the rank and file.

Any strikes or unions that failed to comply with the terms set out in the Accord were crushed with the full backing of the ACTU and the ALP, with few exceptions. The union bureaucracy actively collaborated with the State to demobilise the movement it supposedly led.

Whilst the bureaucracy enjoyed an exceptionally close relationship with the government, union membership collapsed. At the same time, the ACTU's program of union amalgamation created large unions with hundreds of staff members, further weakening the rank and file while strengthening the position of the officials. Union rules were re-written to be less democratic and Left officials closed down the rank and file groups which had previously been their base of support.

Today, the union bureaucracy is much less susceptible to pressure from the membership. Not only do the rules give them unilateral control over decision making processes, but there also aren't the same informal ties back to the workplaces the officials supposedly represent. No longer do officials come mostly from the shop floor. Instead, they form a separate caste from the beginning, getting recruited as organisers straight from university. Many

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officials are former student ALP politicians who see climbing the ranks of a union as a path towards a political career in parliament.

The Labor Party will always sell us out, but we need to recognise that even when it does, it is acting in the interests of the trade union bureaucracy. There cannot be a militant trade union movement in Australia unless the Labor Party's influence is defeated in our unions.

Fighting the destructive influence of the Labor Party requires fighting the bureaucracy. We need to build the power of the rank and file and rebuild democratic processes that the officials have closed down. It is the only way to defend the interests of the working class and to advance the revolutionary struggle against capitalism itself.

THE STRUGGLE AGAINST RACISM

MACG's banner
at the Melbourne
refugee
encampment.



Workers are divided, conquered and controlled as a class, both in Australia and globally, by the racial and ethnic divisions perpetuated by capitalism. This results in horrifically disproportionate living and working conditions for non-white workers, but it also results in worse conditions for all workers. Only the collective power of working class organisation can challenge and dismantle the structures of "white power" which enforce the domination of all, at the primary expense of racialised workers. In this struggle, the right of racially oppressed workers to take action in advance of the wider working class will be key, not only to defending their own rights, but to raising the consciousness of other workers as to where their interests lie.

In any class society, the dominant ideo-

logy is the ideology of the ruling class, so it is unsurprising that white workers who haven't rejected capitalism are vulnerable to accepting racist prejudices. It is also unsurprising that workers, whose conditions are mostly far less comfortable than those of their masters, may express these prejudices in starker terms than those used by the capitalist media. Nevertheless, the source of racism lies in capitalist social relations.

In Australia, workers without permanent residence are at a disadvantage in relation to their employers and the bosses know it. This applies doubly if the workers are undocumented or working outside their visa conditions. This leads to some occupations being dominated by immigrants receiving much less than the minimum wage.

Indigenous people in Australia are primarily treated as an obstacle to the exploitation of land by capital. Subsequently, they are either integrated into the lowest strata of the working class or treated as a completely surplus population. In either case, their very existence is a repudiation of the legitimacy of capitalist Australia, so they are subject to extreme criminalisation and treated as test beds for dehumanising systems of control that are being considered for the wider working class.

As a result of racialisation, bosses can work people harder and for lower wages, while using the fear of replaceability to keep white workers in line. Certain jobs (cleaning, back-of-house hospitality, meat packing, fruit picking, etc) become racialised, while capitalist media spin narratives of migrants "stealing jobs" and drum up racist myths about violent crime.

A lack of working class solidarity is necessary to the continued domination of capital. Whether it is through the explicit violence of the White Australia policy or the apartheid regimes of South Africa or Israel, or the less spectacular violence of modern concentration camps for refugees, mass incarceration of Blak communities and

the temporary migrant labour system, capital always seeks a way to maintain a permanent underclass of the hyper-exploited and oppressed. The racialised, excluded and criminalised do the "dirty" work, the hidden labour, the care labour and the rotten, dangerous jobs.

The struggle against racism is justified firstly as a fight against something evil in itself, but also as a struggle to unite the working class on the only basis possible – that of Touch One, Touch All. Because the dynamics of racism in Australia are different for Indigenous people and immigrants, there will be differences in the methods of struggle, but a common thread will run through both.

Indigenous people in Australia have a long history of struggle and have many well-established demands, though they are often pitched at different levels of ambition. The struggle for land rights and the struggle against police violence are where major strategic battles are fought, while the struggle for Indigenous control of Indigenous organisations and services is vital to the defence and extension of the limited gains won to date. The struggle for treaty has the potential to unite and deepen all other issues. But because it strikes at the very foundation of Australian capitalism, no just treaty is possible this side of a work-

“Indigenous people in Australia are primarily treated as an obstacle to the exploitation of land by capital.”

ers’ revolution. There is thus both great potential and great danger in this issue, which has led to Indigenous people not yet having articulated a common vision of a demand here.

Anarchists in Australia should support the struggles of Indigenous people and attempt to bring the power of the organised working class to bear. A 24 hour protest strike against a cop murder of an Indigenous person would do more good than every Royal Commission in history. Similarly, unionised workers should ensure that no mine is built on Aboriginal land without the full, free and informed consent of First Nations communities. This would eliminate the practice of mining companies shopping around for Indigenous people sufficiently desperate to sign an agreement in return for a pittance.

On the other hand, migrant workers on temporary visas are often inhibited from struggling at all. Here, Anarchists must take up the struggle for full citizenship rights for everyone in the country. A key demand which could get wide support is for all migrants arriving on a work visa to have the right to apply for permanent residence on arrival. This would remove the hold that bosses have over them, preventing them gaining access even to their legal rights like an award wage. The unions should fight hard for this. For asylum seekers, Anarchists should attempt to bring the unions to active support for their rights under the Refugee Convention. Crucially, this would mean not turning back boats full of desperate people, not locking people up on Christmas Island or Nauru and not denying visitor visas to people who are suspected of being refugees. If refugees could fly here, they wouldn’t need to get on leaky boats.

We have to support existing struggles and attempt to win the wider working class to the principle of Touch One, Touch All. Indigenous people, temporary migrant workers and refugees should have the right to control their own struggles against oppression. But it is also in the interests of all workers, racialised or otherwise, to back these movements.



Red & black flags at
Palestine rally in
Melbourne

Anarchism 101: Why the working class?

Progressive activism is alive and well in Melbourne today, but is working class politics?

Israel's genocidal escalation on the people of Gaza is now over a year old. In Melbourne, tens of thousands of people have marched on the streets in weekly demonstrations. Thousands have been involved in community blockades, protests against the arms industry, and in student encampments.

"Palestine" has been the largest and most sustained social movement in Australia for a number of years. One year on, protests continue, but the prevailing sentiment in the movement is demoralisation. Protests, student encampments and community blockades have failed to shift government policy.

This is because the Palestine movement has, so far, been unable to hurt the ruling class where it really matters.

We argue for a working class strategy, because it is the working class that can hit capitalists where it hurts. To win, we need to make Palestine a crisis for the ruling class.

The problem we face is that organised working class power has been on the decline for four decades – not only in Australia, but across much of the industrialised world. Union density (the percentage of workers who are members of a union) has fallen to 12%. Most workers have never gone on strike, let alone over political issues, and most unions lack the genuine democratic structures that would even enable us to raise the argument for strikes. Today,

one of the last bastions of genuine militancy in the Australian workers' movement, the CFMEU, is under attack.

Faced with this dire situation, many activists now grasp for any strategy that could substitute for the loss of organised working class power.

Some point to the student movement, student strikes, and university encampments. Others think that all we need to do is get enough people out in the streets; smashing stuff and fighting with the cops. Instead of strikes, activists organise boycotts. Instead of workplace pickets, we get community blockades. Where demonstrations once saw crowds chanting "the workers united will never be defeated" we now hear "the people united..."

Organised students can cause some disruption. But student movements are limited in their reach, difficult to sustain, and lack the ability to apply sufficient pressure where it really counts. Students should organise on their campuses in solidarity with wider working class struggles, but these actions cannot substitute for working class power.

And needless to say, we have no objection to confronting the police when necessary! But a fight with the



police on the streets does not seriously threaten capitalist profits. The limits of simply getting "more people" on the streets are also plain to see. A protest should be a demonstration; a demonstration of the numbers of workers prepared to take further action if their demands are not met.

"The community" is also a poor substitute for working class organisation. Community blockades of manufacturing sites, ports and other infrastructure correctly identify the importance of disrupting production but they lack the power to achieve what they set out to do. A community blockade (unsupported by workers at the blockaded site) lasts as long as it takes the police to break it up. The costs these actions have imposed are insignificant compared to the profits the arms industry reaps from this war.

The Palestine campaign faces demoralisation because in the main, it

has failed to grapple with the task before us. It is not enough to simply demonstrate a moral objection to the unfolding genocide.

Rebuilding organised and militant working class struggle is essential if we are to build any successful fightback against the depredations of capitalism. We need to make this our task.

The bosses have power in capitalist society because they are the ones that own the land, the machinery, and the equipment necessary for production to take place. Governments exist to maintain that power and are compelled to keep the capitalists happy, or else face capital flight, disinvestment, and the wrath of the capitalist media. Capitalists and governments rely on the value that workers create.

The working class has unique power because of our position in relation to capital. Capitalists might own everything, but it is workers who actually do the work. When workers get organised and walk off the job, things grind to a halt. When our work is being put to destructive use, we can refuse to take part. If we so choose, we can even kick the boss out and continue working in our own interests. No group other than workers, organised on the job, can

so effectively cut off the ruling class from their profits or the ultimate source of their power: control over production. This is why rebuilding working class organisation is crucial to winning the struggles we face today and towards building a revolution.

Students and community activists may be able to win victories here and there, but no other group is capable of fundamentally transforming how we produce and distribute the things that people need and want. No other group has the knowledge or skills required to take over the various industries now controlled by corporations and the State, and to repurpose them in service of human needs.

This knowledge, spread throughout the working class, will be necessary if we want to ever abolish this rotten capitalist system. To get rid of bosses, landlords, and politicians once and for all; to build a free community of equals, where no one is compelled by a fear of poverty to work for a boss; we need to build workers' power. Without it, revolution is impossible. And only through revolution can we finally be free to choose our own paths in life, without fear of hunger, war, or the destruction of the natural world.



ANARCHIST

POLITICAL SCHOOL



The Anarchist Political School is an introduction to the revolutionary ideas and strategies of anarchist communism. Learn about how capitalism and governments really work, how we can fight the ruling class, and why we need a revolution!

All sessions consist of a reading, which we read and discuss together. There is no homework or prior preparation required.

Sessions currently held fortnightly in Coburg, St Kilda and Northcote. Sign up to start the series at melbacg.au/politicalschool or scan the QR code. If you have any questions feel free to email us at:

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